

Chapter 2

Manilal Dhandho

The Patel Motel Dhandho story is interesting, but it appears that this was a huge one-time opportunity in the early 1970s. It does not look like the same could be replicated today. Well, let's refute that perspective by examining the journey Manilal Chaudhari has embarked on. Manilal is not a Patel, but he is their first cousin. Like the Patels, he hails from Gujarat and has virtually identical cultural and religious beliefs. Like the stereotypical Patel, the entrepreneurial Dhandho genes are deeply entrenched.

It was a very pretty, sunny Southern California Valentine's Day in 2006 when I left my office in Irvine to visit Manilal at his Best Western motel in Moreno Valley, California—about 50 miles inland in the desert. A mutual friend had briefly described Manilal's interesting entrepreneurial story to me. I was intrigued and contacted him to arrange an interview.

Manilal is an unassuming, pleasant 54-year-old guy who comes across as a very honest, hardworking, and likeable fellow. He was born and raised in Gujarat in a family with four brothers and two sisters. One of his brothers had migrated to the United States in the 1970s and had settled in the San Francisco Bay area. Manilal had trained and worked as an accountant in India. In 1991, his brother sponsored him, and he was able to get his U.S. green card and migrate to the United States with his wife and kids.

He arrived in San Francisco with virtually no cash or assets. His brother hosted them, and Manilal began to look for a job so he could support his family. Manilal spoke English before he came to the United States and had already been in the United States for 15 years when we met. Even so, I found it hard to understand Manilal's broken and heavily accented English—especially in our phone conversations. It was easier in person, but it would have been a huge liability for him 15 years ago in the job market.